Spot the Places Where Mom's Care Depends on One Person

Four prompts to map who does what for Mom, test the backup plans everyone assumes exist, write down the small gaps before they grow, and name the changes that should bring you back to the list.

Where you are

Mom is doing well at home. A neighbor drives her to appointments, your brother handles the bills, and you call every evening. It works, and nobody has asked what happens if one piece stops.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can name the tasks that rest on a single person, say which backup arrangements are real and which are hopes, and describe the changes that would mean it's time to look again.

A one-page map with four headings: Who Does What, Depends on One Person, Backup Confirmed or Not, and Changes That Mean We Should Look Again.

Before you start

- A list of the people who help Mom, including the ones who'd say they don't do much.
- Your sense of a normal week for her.
- Any backup arrangement you've heard mentioned, even in passing. Rough notes are fine.

PROMPT 1

Map who does what

WHY THIS MATTERS

A working arrangement hides its own structure. You know the neighbor drives, but you may not have noticed that nobody else can, or that the evening phone call is the only daily check anyone makes.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your list of helpers and what each one does, however informal.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother lives at home and several people help her. Here is who does what, as best I know it:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]

> Make a table: WHO, WHAT THEY DO, HOW OFTEN, and COULD ANYONE ELSE DO THIS. In the last column write ONLY THEM where I've named no one else, SOMEONE COULD where another person has the ability, and NOT SURE where I don't know. Then list the tasks marked ONLY THEM in one place so I can see them together. Include the small things, like the phone call every evening, not just the big ones.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How long the ONLY THEM list is, and whether your own name is on most of it.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share the table with the people on it and ask them to correct it.

PROMPT 2

Test the backup plans

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families say “well, if that happened, Aunt Carol would step in.” Aunt Carol may not know this. A backup that hasn't been agreed to is a wish, and wishes don't drive anyone to the doctor.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Every backup arrangement you've heard the family mention.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> These are the backup arrangements my family tends to mention when we talk about my mother's care:
>
> [PASTE THE BACKUPS YOU'VE HEARD]
>
> For each one, give me three columns: THE BACKUP WE ASSUME, HAS THAT PERSON ACTUALLY AGREED, and WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT. Use CONFIRMED, ASSUMED, or NONE for the middle column, based only on what I've said. For every ASSUMED or NONE, write one plain sentence I could use to ask that person directly. Then list the tasks from my map that have no backup at all, in their own list.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How few rows say CONFIRMED. That's normal, and it's useful to know now.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask one person this month whether they'd really be willing. Write down what they say.

PROMPT 3

Write down the small gaps now

WHY THIS MATTERS

Nothing has gone wrong, which is exactly why the small unmet needs get ignored. Written down today, they're a note. Discovered during a crisis, they're one more emergency.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Anything about Mom's days that feels a little thin, even if you've never said it out loud.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I notice about my mother's days that doesn't feel quite covered, even though nothing has gone wrong:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> List each one as a need that's met partly, met late, or not met. Describe each in neutral words: what is happening, not what's wrong with it. Give me columns for THE NEED, WHAT HAPPENS NOW, and WHAT I'VE SEEN THAT MAKES ME MENTION IT. Don't suggest a service, a device, or a move. Then tell me which items I've described from memory rather than from something I watched recently, so I know which ones to check.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Items you've been noticing for months without writing down, and items you're not sure are still true.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

On your next visit, watch for the items you described from memory.

PROMPT 4

Name the changes worth watching, and put it on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

A map of today is only useful if you know when to redraw it. The changes that matter are usually ordinary and noticeable: a helper moves, a stair gets harder, a bill goes unpaid.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've gathered about my mother's support:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Lay it out on one page with four headings: WHO DOES WHAT, DEPENDS ON ONE PERSON, BACKUP CONFIRMED OR NOT, and CHANGES THAT MEAN WE SHOULD LOOK AGAIN. Under the last heading, list changes I could actually notice, in my mother, in the people who help her, or in the house, that would mean this map needs redoing. Don't estimate when any of these might happen, and don't say what they would mean for her health.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd be comfortable showing Mom, with nothing on it that reads like a verdict.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page where you'll see it, and start the next step below.

Turn the map into a complete picture

Your map covers the help you know about. The care interview asks about the parts of Mom's daily life you haven't thought to mention and records what's in place for each one. The Family Care Profile it produces is the file you and a professional will work from when something does change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›